

## India: Higher exports, higher imports, wider deficit

FY27 CA deficit is likely at 2.4% of GDP, with a large BOP deficit. Additional measures to manage the BOP are on the way.

*India's April trade deficit widened to a larger-than-expected USD28.4bn (Consensus: USD26.0bn), driven by higher import and resilient export growth, the latter similar to the experience in other Asian economies. Meanwhile, stable import growth could signal resilient domestic demand, although we believe price effects could be exaggerating the rise. Services trade surplus remained robust at USD20.6bn in April vs USD21.0bn in March, with strong export growth (13.4% y-o-y vs 7.3% in March).*

### April trade deficit widens

In the second month of the Iran war, India's merchandise trade deficit widened to USD28.4bn in April from USD20.7bn in March, above expectations (Consensus: USD26.0bn, Nomura: USD25.5bn, Figure 1). Price effects have ballooned both the export and the import bill, but the breakdown shows that the wider deficit was mainly led by higher imports. In contrast, exports held up, despite trade disruptions (higher insurance and shipping costs).

#### What has driven the exports pickup?

Export growth surged to 13.8% y-o-y in April from -7.4% in March, significantly above expectations (Nomura: -4.4%), reflecting not just higher prices, but also an incremental pick-up in volume growth (Figure 2). Electronics posted the strongest growth in exports (40.3% y-o-y), reflecting higher prices and volume share gain in smartphone assembly, while the strength in petroleum products and chemical exports largely reflects price effects, in our view. In contrast, textiles and gems & jewellery export growth continued to contract, with the latter likely weighed down by slower shipments to the Persian Gulf (Figures 3 and 4).

Partially available geographical break-up of exports shows that while export growth to key markets like the US and select European partners remains weak, exports to China/HK, Singapore, and Vietnam have remained strong (Figure 5). Exports to Middle East destinations like Saudi Arabia and UAE continued to contract, but at a slower pace than in March.

#### Import growth drivers

Import growth rose to 10.0% y-o-y in April from -6.5% in March, above expectations (Nomura: -5.0%). Oil imports contracted on a y-o-y basis, but picked up sequentially, as higher cost of imported oil likely more than offset the drop in volumes. Gold imports surged (81.7% y-o-y), despite media reports that gold shipments were stuck at customs owing to administrative delays from ambiguity on taxation.

Core import growth also posted strong growth of 15.4% y-o-y in April from 10.2% in March, which we estimate reflects, both price and volume effects (Figure 6). That said, it seems that the pick-up in core import growth has been primarily driven by consumer goods, particularly electronics, while investment/industrial goods growth continued to moderate (Figure 7). Supply bottlenecks also weighed on imports of chemicals.

### Nomura view: More BOP measures are on the way

The resilience of exports in April is in line with the strength in other Asian economies, and **Nomura's leading index** of Asian exports points to continued pickup. Meanwhile, stable import growth signals resilient domestic demand, although we believe price effects could be exaggerating the rise. In our baseline, we expect the current account deficit to average 2.4% of GDP in FY27, and weak capital inflows suggest the balance of payment is tracking a deficit of ~USD70bn. On the policy front, the government has imposed curbs on

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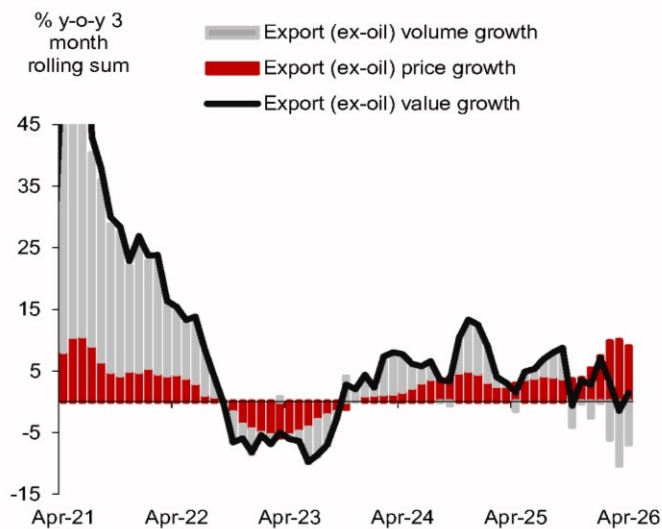
*gold imports*, and raised *retail prices* of petrol/diesel to reduce the current account deficit (CAD). We expect more measures to manage the *BOP pressures* in the coming days.

**Fig. 1: Trade at a glance**

| % y-o-y                                                   | Dec-25       | Jan-26       | Feb-26       | Mar-26       | Apr-26       |
|-----------------------------------------------------------|--------------|--------------|--------------|--------------|--------------|
| <b>Exports</b>                                            | <b>1.1</b>   | <b>0.4</b>   | <b>-0.8</b>  | <b>-7.4</b>  | <b>13.8</b>  |
| Oil                                                       | -12.3        | 5.7          | -40.2        | 5.7          | 34.7         |
| Non-oil/gems & jewellery                                  | 3.4          | 2.0          | 6.6          | -7.5         | 10.4         |
| <b>Imports</b>                                            | <b>10.3</b>  | <b>19.8</b>  | <b>25.0</b>  | <b>-6.5</b>  | <b>10.0</b>  |
| Oil                                                       | 5.9          | -0.3         | 9.0          | -35.9        | -10.0        |
| Gems & jewellery                                          | 14.2         | 242.2        | 182.9        | -17.8        | 51.1         |
| Non-oil/gems & jewellery                                  | 11.1         | 2.5          | 14.0         | 10.2         | 15.4         |
| <b>Trade balance (USD bn)</b>                             | <b>-26.2</b> | <b>-34.8</b> | <b>-27.1</b> | <b>-20.7</b> | <b>-28.4</b> |
| <b>Sequential momentum (% m-o-m, seasonally adjusted)</b> |              |              |              |              |              |
| <b>Exports</b>                                            | <b>-10.8</b> | <b>-0.9</b>  | <b>-1.2</b>  | <b>-5.9</b>  | <b>21.8</b>  |
| Oil                                                       | 0.2          | 2.1          | -32.0        | 57.1         | 47.8         |
| Non-oil/gems & jewellery                                  | -10.3        | 0.5          | 0.8          | -14.2        | 22.7         |
| <b>Imports</b>                                            | <b>2.7</b>   | <b>13.8</b>  | <b>-11.3</b> | <b>-11.5</b> | <b>30.6</b>  |
| Oil                                                       | 4.4          | -3.5         | -8.4         | -17.7        | 60.9         |
| Non-oil/gems & jewellery                                  | 0.1          | 2.8          | -0.3         | -1.7         | 12.0         |
| <b>Trade balance (sa, USD bn)</b>                         | <b>-28.0</b> | <b>-37.3</b> | <b>-29.4</b> | <b>-24.0</b> | <b>-34.3</b> |

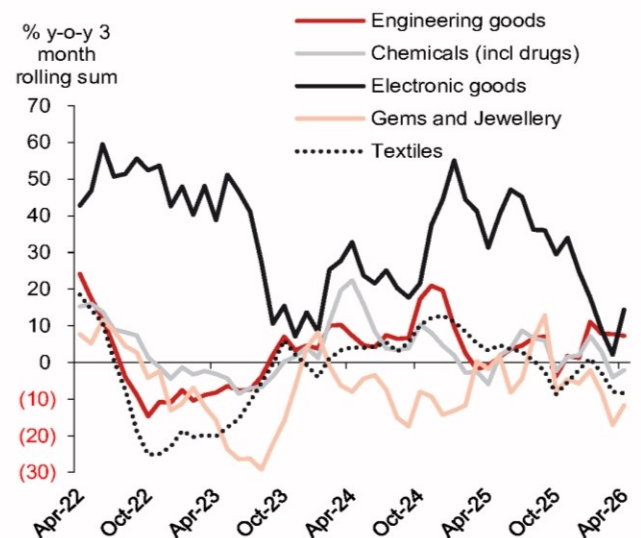
Source: CEIC and Nomura Global Economics

**Fig. 2: Core export growth: price versus volume**



Source: The World Bank, Ministry of Commerce, CEIC and Nomura Global Economics

**Fig. 3: Export growth by key categories**



Source: CEIC and Nomura Global Economics

Fig. 4: Exports by products

| % y-o-y                    | Nov-25 | Dec-25 | Jan-26 | Feb-26 | Mar-26 | Apr-26 |
|----------------------------|--------|--------|--------|--------|--------|--------|
| Exports                    | 18.6   | 1.1    | 0.4    | (0.8)  | (7.4)  | 13.8   |
| Oil                        | 4.5    | (12.3) | 5.7    | (40.2) | 5.7    | 34.7   |
| Non-Oil                    | 20.3   | 3.1    | (0.2)  | 6.4    | (9.2)  | 9.0    |
| <b>By products</b>         |        |        |        |        |        |        |
| Agri & allied products     | (1.2)  | (8.2)  | (9.7)  | 0.5    | (14.6) | (1.9)  |
| Marine products            | 15.5   | 11.7   | 13.3   | 13.3   | 0.8    | 14.7   |
| Ores & minerals            | 46.8   | 21.0   | 13.0   | (0.9)  | (8.0)  | 13.3   |
| Leather products           | 5.9    | (3.8)  | (7.7)  | (4.8)  | (14.4) | 0.4    |
| Gems & jewellery           | 27.8   | (2.1)  | (23.0) | 4.1    | (29.4) | (7.1)  |
| Pharmaceuticals            | 20.9   | 5.7    | 1.0    | 3.4    | (23.2) | 7.1    |
| Chemicals                  | 18.5   | 1.1    | (0.2)  | 6.9    | (2.0)  | 7.3    |
| Electronic goods           | 39.0   | 16.8   | 0.3    | 10.4   | (3.3)  | 40.3   |
| Engineering goods          | 23.8   | 1.3    | 10.4   | 12.9   | 1.1    | 8.8    |
| Textiles & allied products | 8.5    | 0.1    | (3.8)  | (5.0)  | (14.9) | (4.7)  |
| Petroleum products         | 11.7   | (6.5)  | 8.5    | (40.1) | 5.9    | 34.7   |
| Others                     | 4.9    | (1.3)  | (5.0)  | 5.4    | (13.9) | 10.5   |

Source: CEIC and Nomura Global Economics

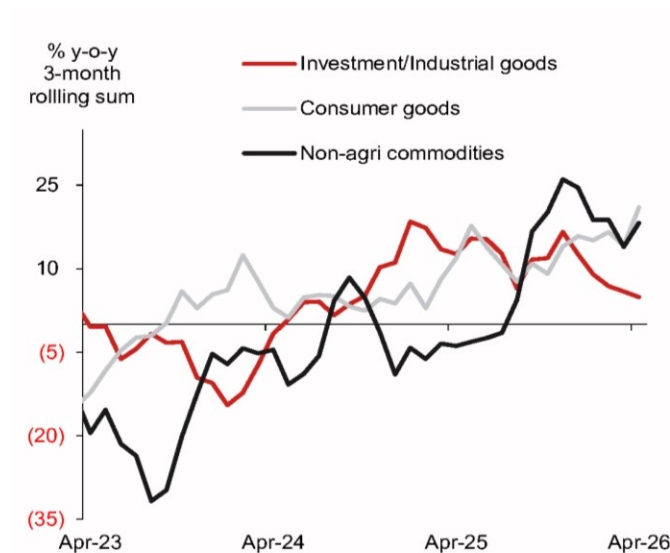
Fig. 5: Exports across select destinations

|        | European countries*                        | US    | China | UK    | Middle East countries** | Others |
|--------|--------------------------------------------|-------|-------|-------|-------------------------|--------|
| Months | Share in FY25 (% of total exports)         |       |       |       |                         |        |
|        | 11.2                                       | 19.8  | 3.3   | 3.3   | 11.1                    | 38.0   |
|        | Share in latest month (% of total exports) |       |       |       |                         |        |
|        | 8.2                                        | 14.5  | 4.1   | 2.8   | 4.7                     | 41.9   |
|        | Growth rates (% y-o-y)                     |       |       |       |                         |        |
| Apr-25 | -36.9                                      | 16.2  | 11.1  | -20.3 | 7.5                     | 8.4    |
| May-25 | -0.7                                       | 14.9  | 22.5  | -20.0 | -13.4                   | -4.8   |
| Jun-25 | -10.5                                      | 24.6  | 15.4  | -9.5  | -10.5                   | -5.3   |
| Jul-25 | 2.4                                        | 27.8  | 28.0  | 7.8   | 14.4                    | 15.0   |
| Aug-25 | 5.5                                        | 6.6   | 21.6  | 1.5   | 14.3                    | 7.6    |
| Sep-25 | -11.6                                      | -12.6 | 33.0  | 11.9  | 21.3                    | 18.6   |
| Oct-25 | -22.5                                      | -8.5  | 41.0  | -27.1 | -9.1                    | -1.7   |
| Nov-25 | 4.6                                        | 21.7  | 89.3  | 15.3  | 7.9                     | 29.2   |
| Dec-25 | -8.4                                       | -10.0 | 66.5  | -8.4  | 0.3                     | 1.9    |
| Jan-26 | 12.2                                       | -25.1 | 55.3  | -7.9  | 23.2                    | 4.0    |
| Feb-26 | -10.7                                      | -12.9 | 32.2  | -4.7  | -2.9                    | 8.9    |
| Mar-26 | -22.3                                      | -37.8 | 28.1  | -13.5 | -58.3                   | 0.6    |
| Apr-26 | -12.3                                      | -24.7 | 27.0  | 14.8  | -29.6                   | 30.9   |

Note: \*Consists of Germany, France, Netherlands and Italy; \*\*Consists of Saudi Arabia and UAE.

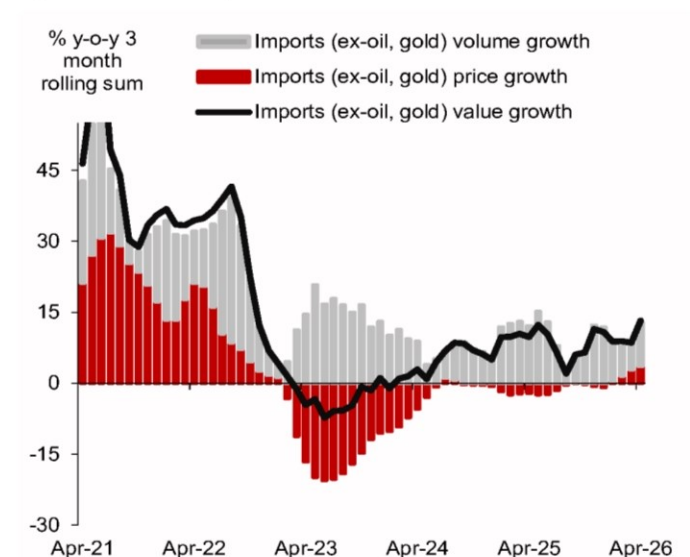
Source: CEIC and Nomura Global Economics

Fig. 6: Core import growth by categories



Source: CEIC and Nomura Global Economics

Fig. 7: Core import growth: price versus volume



Source: The World Bank, Ministry of Commerce, CEIC, and Nomura Global Economics



# Appendix A-1

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